HAMASPIK LEOVDEI HASHEM

Misvot, Mind & Humility: How the Torah Dismantles Pride

Given Monday 4 May 2026 · HaMaspik LeOvdei HaShem, Chapter 7 Part 3

Sefer: HaMaspik L'Ovdei Hashem (Kifayat al-Abidin) — Rabbi Avraham ben HaRambam **Chapter:** Perek 7 (ענוה — Humility) — Part 3 **Edition:** Feldheim **This week:** The 12 mitzvot designed to instill humility + the beginning of philosophical analysis (Method 3)

Recap: Chapter 7 So Far

The Definition (Part 1)

- Humility = recognizing one's true status, not exaggerating it (up or down)
- Two dimensions: internal and external
- Two relationships: vis-à-vis Hakadosh Baruch Hu and vis-à-vis other people
- Humility ≠ self-debasement

Three Methods of Training Toward Humility

1. **Personal/experiential** — reflecting on what causes arrogance, surrounding oneself with humble people *(covered Part 1)*
2. **Through the Torah** — two sub-methods:

- 2a. Stories in Tanakh of humble vs. arrogant figures *(covered Parts 1 & 2)*
- 2b. Mitzvot in the Torah designed to cultivate humility *(this week)*

1. **Philosophical analysis** *(begins this week)*

Last Week's Tour of Tanakh

Korach, Datan & Aviram, Nadav & Avihu, Shaul, Doeg, Achitofel, Avshalom, Yoav, Adoniyah, Rechavam, Yeravam, Uziyahu, Chizkiyahu — every figure shows that greatness offers no protection from the fall of arrogance.

Opening Discussion: What Mitzvot Train Us in Humility?

Before reading Rabbi Avraham's list, the class brainstormed possibilities. Several excellent suggestions came up — none of which Rabbi Avraham himself lists, but all valid:

- **Tzedakah** — recognizing that everything comes from Hashem
- **Kibbud Av Va'Em** — they brought you into the world (more accurately hakarat hatov)
- **Mahatzit HaShekel** — equal contribution rich and poor (though primarily for the census)
- **Removing the deshen** — the kohen performing menial-seeming tasks

- **Lo tikom v'lo titor** (no revenge, no grudges) — recognizing Hashem is the arbiter, not you (Rambam mentions this elsewhere in Sefer HaMitzvot)

Rabbi Avraham's important caveat: a single mitzvah can carry **multiple training purposes**. He brought "loving the ger" earlier (Chapter 4) under the heading of **compassion**. Here he brings it again under **humility**. Same mitzvah, multiple functions.

The 12 Mitzvot Designed to Instill Humility

Mitzvah 1 — Loving the Ger (Convert/Stranger)

כי גרים הייתם בארץ מצרים

- The Torah commands love and kindness toward the ger
- The given reason: **you were once strangers in Egypt**
- Even the prohibition not to despise an Egyptian ger — though Egyptians enslaved us — applies, **because you were once a stranger in his land**
- The training: **remember the lowliness of being an outsider**, and never let your heart become haughty when you are the insider

Mitzvah 2 — Remembering Egyptian Bondage

וזכרת כי עבד היית במצרים

- Beyond the basic reason (to keep the Torah out of gratitude), this remembrance directly cultivates humility
- **Rabbi Sacks z"l's framing:** psychology shows the abused often become abusers. The Torah commands us repeatedly: *remember Egypt — and do not repeat it.* Don't perpetuate what you suffered.

Mitzvah 3 — Land Cannot Be Sold in Perpetuity (This Week's Parsha — Behar)

כי גרים ותושבים אתם עמדי

- Land returns to its ancestral owner in the Yovel
- Buy in the second year of the cycle → 48 years; buy in year 40 → 9 years; either way, the land returns
- The reason: **you are guests on My land**
- Counters the arrogance of wealth: even your property is not permanently yours. You don't have carte blanche just because you have means.

Mitzvah 4 — Bikurim and the Bikurim Declaration

ולקחת מראשית כל פרי האדמה...

- The first fruits, brought in a basket, given personally to the Kohen
- **The Mishna's striking detail:** even King Agrippas carried the basket on his shoulder all the way to the Azarah
- The verse confirms this: ולקח הכהן הטנא מידך — *the Kohen takes the basket from your hand*
- **The humility encoded:** whoever you are — even the king — you must come yourself, subdue yourself before the Kohen, and acknowledge dependence on Hashem

Mitzvah 5 — The Bikurim Declaration & Bowing

- The text of the declaration is **entirely about bondage in Egypt, redemption, and gratitude for the land**

- The Torah commands bowing: **והשתחוית לפני ה' אלוקיך**
- **Why specifically when bringing first fruits?** Because of the warning in Eikev:

פן תאכל ושבעת ובתים טובים תבנה... ורם לבבך ושכחת את ה' אלהיך

- The natural human pattern: poverty makes us turn to Hashem; abundance makes us forget Him
- Therefore, **specifically at the moment of abundance** (first fruits, full harvest), the Torah inserts an act of bowing and gratitude. The training is precisely targeted at the moment of greatest temptation toward arrogance.

Mitzvah 6 — General Confession (Vidui)

והתודו את חטאתם אשר עשו

- Confession of sin is a Torah mitzvah — both the Yom Kippur vidui and the daily/private confession
- Rabbi Avraham cites: **והתודו את עונם... אז יכנע לבבם הערל ואז ירצו את עונם** — *then their blocked heart will be subdued, and then their iniquity will be atoned*
- **The mechanism:** the act of confession is itself an act of self-subjugation. It directly produces hachna'ah.

Mitzvah 7 — The Banishment of the Impure from the Camp

וישלחו מן המחנה כל צרוע וכל זב וכל טמא לנפש

- Different levels of impurity, different distances of removal from the camp
- **Most striking case: the metzora** (one with tzaraat)
- Clothes torn, head uncovered, mouth covered, called "tamei tamei"
- Banished from all three camps: בדד ישב מחוץ למחנה מושבו
- Treated like a mourner

Why the Metzora Is Treated Like a Mourner

A beautiful idea (not from Rambam himself):

- What distinguishes a human from an animal is **koach hadibbur** (power of speech) — ויהי האדם לנפש חיה → רוח ממללא
- When a person corrupts speech (lashon hara), they have, in a sense, "died" as a human — losing their distinguishing identity
- They mourn for their lost humanity until they are healed
- The whole experience is one prolonged training in humility

Mitzvah 8 — Standing for Elders and Honoring Sages

מפני שיבה תקום והדרת פני זקן

- Direct cultivation of derech eretz, hachna'ah, and humility
- The act of standing for someone older or wiser physically expresses an inward acknowledgment

Mitzvah 9 — No Yeast or Honey on the Mizbe'ach

כי כל שאור וכל דבש לא תקטירו ממנו אשה לה'

- A more drush-style explanation: yeast rises, honey froths
- These represent **expansion beyond one's true measure** — the very symbol of arrogance

- The Mizbe'ach exists, per the Ramban, so we contemplate that *this should be us* — the sacrifice substitutes for the self
- Therefore, anything that symbolizes self-inflation is banned from the altar

Mitzvah 10 — The Prohibition of Matzevah

לא תקים לך מצבה אשר שנא ה' אלוהיך

- A pillar to be worshipped — physically elevating an object
- Rabbi Avraham reads this as part of the same theme: the rejection of *raising up* in any form

Mitzvah 11 — The Prohibition of Even Maskit

- An even maskit (debated among Rishonim — Rambam: a stone placed before an idol for prostration; others: a stone floor)
- Rabbi Avraham's reading: it is fundamentally an act of **elevating oneself** (above the natural ground) for the purpose of worship
- The contrast verse: **ממעמקים קראתיך ה'** — *from the depths I called You* — true prayer comes from lowliness, not elevation

Practical Halachic Outflow

- The Gemara derives from this: **one must not pray standing on an elevated place** (Shulchan Aruch, OC 90):

המתפלל לא יעמוד גבי מיטה ולא גבי כיסא ולא גבי ספסל ולא גבי מקום גבוה

- Exceptions: the chazan on the bimah (representing the tzibbur), or someone ill
- The principle: prayer arises from the depths

Mitzvah 12 — The King's Sefer Torah

והיה כשבתו על כיסא ממלכתו... וכתב לו את משנה התורה

- The king must write his own personal Sefer Torah and read from it constantly
- **Two stated reasons:**

1. To learn yirat Hashem and observe the mitzvot

that his heart not be lifted above his brothers — **לבלתי רום לבבו מאחיו**

- The king is **most at risk** of arrogance because of his power → therefore he is given the **most intensive antidote**: constant Torah study designed specifically to humble him
- The reward: **למען יאריך ימים** — long kingship for him and his descendants
- The contrast: every king we saw last week who fell — fell because they did not internalize this

Closing Verse

ידרך ענוים במשפט וילמד ענוים דרכו

- Hashem leads the humble on His path
- **The path of humility = the path of Hashem.** The 12 mitzvot above (and many others) are not random — they are the structured curriculum by which Hashem trains us to walk His path.

Quick-Reference Table — The 12 Mitzvot

#	Mitzvah	Mechanism
1	Love the ger	Remember being the outsider
2	Remember Egyptian bondage	Don't repeat the abuse you suffered
3	Land returns in Yovel	You are a guest, even on your own land
4	Bikurim (bringing)	Even the king carries the basket
5	Bikurim declaration & bowing	Targets the moment of abundance
6	Vidui	Direct self-subjugation
7	Banishment of the impure (esp. metzora)	Imposed isolation forces self-reflection
8	Standing for elders	Daily physical expression of submission
9	No yeast or honey on Mizbe'ach	Reject symbols of self-inflation
10	No matzevah	Reject objects of elevation
11	No even maskit	Reject elevation in worship
12	King's Sefer Torah	Most-at-risk receives most intensive antidote

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Method 3: Philosophical / Intellectual Analysis

The third method of training begins now. Instead of stories or mitzvot, this method works through reasoning: **what could a person possibly be arrogant about, and why does close analysis dissolve each potential basis for that arrogance?**

The structure: Rabbi Avraham splits potential bases for arrogance into **three categories**, with each one analytically dismantled.

1. Purely physical things (food, drink, sex, health)
2. Material things with a metaphysical edge (wealth, power, authority)
3. Genuinely spiritual things (intellect, character, even prophecy)

The Foundational Premise — Chomer and Tzura

Every human is composed of:

- **Chomer** — matter (the physical, corporal)
- **Tzura** — form (the spiritual, the meaning-seeking element)

As Rabbi Sacks framed it: humans are "the mammals who look for meaning in life." We are mammals AND we are searching beings.

All our characteristics emanate from one or the other. The analysis below works through what each domain can — and cannot — offer as legitimate grounds for pride.

Category 1 — Purely Physical Things

Why There Is Nothing to Boast About

- In the physical realm, **there is no difference between a human and the lowest mammal**
- We share with all animals: eating, drinking, reproducing, sleeping, falling ill, recovering
- Rabbi Avraham (echoing the Rambam in *The Guide* III:8): the **sense of touch is the most embarrassing of the senses**, because it is the most shared with animals
- Why would you take pride in something animals do exactly the same way?

What About Health?

- A person says: "I am healthy and physically perfect."
- **Reality check:** physical health is exquisitely fragile
- A change of climate
- A bit too much or too little food
- A minor change → everything turns
- We see this constantly. People who are healthy one moment are gravely ill the next. **What is there to be proud of in something so easily lost?**

What About Indulgence?

- A person says: "I have all the food I want, all the drink, every desire fulfilled."
- **Counter-argument:** the very same desires you think you have mastered are the source of the greatest suffering

Examples

- **Gluttony** → Rambam in Hilchot De'ot: *99 of 100 illnesses come from overeating.* The very thing that gives life takes it
- **Indigestion and revulsion** → the pasuk: **כל אכל תתעב נפשם** — when one is ill, all food becomes repulsive
- **Excessive intercourse** → the medicine of those days held this leads to weakness and disease (and the underlying point — that overindulgence in any drive damages the body — remains valid)

The Galen Principle

כי גידולו ריבויו וחיותו של היצור חי הם עילת התמעטותו ניבונו ומיתתו

The Greek physician Galen and others: **the very things that produce growth and life are also the causes of decline and death.** Extremity is destruction.

Conclusion of Category 1

How can a person take pride in a state that **he himself is causing to be undone**? Pride in physical things is pride in something that, by its nature, contains the seeds of its own dismantling.

Category 2 — Material Things with a Metaphysical Edge

These are things that depend on the physical but are not purely physical — they are **enabled by matter but exist as goods in a different sense**: wealth, power, authority, ambition, position.

What People Take Pride In

- Wealth, beautiful clothes, beautiful homes, power, rulership, leadership, the satisfaction of ambition
- David captured this attitude: **ויבטח ברוב עשרו יעוז בהוותו** — *he trusted in his great wealth, was emboldened by his power*

Why This Too Is Hollow

1. These Things Generate Strife

- Money and power → jealousy, hatred, enemies, rivals, anxiety
- The constant fear, vigilance, weight of responsibility, competition

Source	Teaching
Pirkei Avot	מרבה נכסים מרבה דאגה — *more property, more worry*
Kohelet	עושר שמור לבעליו לרעתו — *wealth kept for its owner to his detriment*
Avot	הוי קבל וקיים — *be obscure and you'll endure* (Rashi: ofel — the more obscure, the more permanent)
Mishlei	טוב פת חרבה ושלוה בה מבית מלא זבחי ריב — *better dry bread with serenity than a house full of feasting and quarrels*

2. The Lived Reality

How often do we see:

- Wealth as the cause of family rifts? Inheritance fights only happen in families where there is enough to fight over. A small inheritance generates no court cases — the more there is, the worse the fighting.
- People injured or killed because of their money?
- Wealth as a magnet for trouble?

The Test Case — Kings

התבונן על מצב המלכים שהם יותר נכבדים מבני אדם ויותר עשירים...

Kings have:

- The most honor
- The most wealth
- The most fulfillment of physical desire
- **The most arrogance**

But they also have:

- The most need for security and protection
- The greatest internal suffering — anxiety has no limit at their level

- Constant entanglement in wars
- And their endings: **most kings do not die natural deaths** — killed in war, assassinated openly with the sword, killed secretly through cunning, or destroyed early through illness brought on by their own indulgence in food, drink, and excess

Conclusion of Category 2

How can a person take pride in things that:

- Are temporal — gone in a moment
- Generate suffering proportional to their amount
- Lead to violent and premature death in their fullest expression?

Important Caveat

Rabbi Avraham is **not** saying don't make money or be ambitious. That would be against Torah hashkafa. The point is the difference between **comfortable provision** and **amassment-as-identity**. The arrogance and false security in wealth is the target — not honest pursuit of livelihood.

The Outlier — David HaMelech

David is the rare example of a king who had everything yet did not fall:

Trait	Source
Inner humility	ולבי חלל בקרבי
Hung around righteous people	חבר אני לכל אשר יראוך
Despised the arrogant	גבה עינים ורחב לבב אתו לא אוכל
Praised the humble	Mizmor 15 — מי יגור באהלך...
Talked of the reward of the humble	וענוים ירשו ארץ והתענגו על רב שלום

Two readings of נבזה בעיניו נמאס in Mizmor 15:

- Rashi & others: those whom Hashem rejects (arrogant) → the humble person rejects them
- **Rabbeinu Bechaye:** *in his own eyes* he feels lowly — recognizes his own deficiencies

David is the proof that one *can* hold power and wealth without arrogance — but it requires extraordinary inner work.

Category 3 — Spiritual / Intellectual Excellence

This is the most dangerous category — and the one most likely to trip up the person who has worked hard on themselves.

A person says: "Fine, I accept I'm not better than anyone in physical things, and money/power are vanities. **But I am genuinely wiser. I have worked harder on my character. Surely *that* is grounds for pride?**"

Rabbi Avraham's answer is in two layers.

Layer 1 — Compared to Real Perfection, You Are Nothing

Whatever level you have reached — even the highest — is **כאין וכאפס** (as nothing and naught) compared to true perfection.

זאת מפני המסך של החומר האנושי המעכב בעד השגת השלמות

The very fact of being human, embodied in chomer, places a **screen** between you and true perfection. Your highest is asymptotic to a level you can never reach.

Layer 2 — Even the Highest Spiritual Achievement Is Lost to Tiny Physical Disturbances

This is the powerful argument. **Even prophecy** — the highest perfection a human can reach — is undone by:

- Hunger
- Thirst
- Fatigue
- Sadness
- Anger
- Other physical states

How can you take pride in something so dependent on physical conditions you don't fully control?

Examples Cited

Yaakov Avinu

- During the **22 years separated from Yosef**, prophecy left him because of his sadness
- It returned only when he saw the wagons and his spirit revived: **ותחי רוח יעקב אביהם** — Targum: *the spirit of prophecy returned to Yaakov our father*

Yaakov During the 20 Years with Lavan

- A novel suggestion of Rabbi Avraham (he doesn't seem to have a clear precedent): no prophecy is recorded during this entire period
- Why? Two reasons:

1. **Physical exhaustion** — היתי ביום אכלני חרב וקרח בלילה ותדד שנתי מעיני (heat by day, frost by night, no sleep)
2. **Constant mental engagement with Lavan's deception** — והחלפת את משכרתי עשרת מנים (you changed my wages ten times)

- Both physical strain and material distraction blocked prophetic capacity for two decades

Yitzchak's Blessing

- Yitzchak insisted on tasty food and (in Yaakov's case) wine **before he could bless**
- Why? Because the soul, when channeling spiritual blessing, requires **physical balance** as its substrate
- The physical body must be in a calibrated state for spiritual transmission to occur

Elisha

- Explicit verse: **קחו לי מנגן** — *bring me a musician*
- Music was used to actively **summon** prophetic states

The Schools of Bnei HaNevi'im

- Schools for prophets — they trained in meditation, music, harp, drum, flute

- Prophecy was **cultivated** through deliberate physical and emotional preparation
- This proves the dependency: even the highest perfection requires careful physical setup

Application to Intellect (Not Just Prophecy)

The Chachamim said:

> אין השכינה שורה לא מתוך עצבות ולא מתוך עצלות *The Shechina does not rest amid sadness or laziness*

The Gemara extends this directly:

אמר רב וכן לדבר הלכה *And so too for matters of halacha*

You **cannot reach depth in Torah** when:

- You are sad
- You are hungry
- You are physically uncomfortable
- You are fatigued

The **same dependency on physical conditions** that limits prophecy limits intellectual penetration.

The Final Move — Moshe Rabbeinu

The strongest example. Moshe was the greatest prophet who ever lived. What stopped him from reaching even higher?

כי לא יראני האדם וחי

Hashem says: *while you are human, you cannot fully attain Me.* The very fact of being embodied placed a ceiling.

And what does the Torah say about Moshe?

ענו מאד מכל האדם אשר על פני האדמה

The most humble human ever to live.

The Paradox at the Heart of This

The greater you become, **the more humble you become** — because:

- You see how high you've reached AND
- You see how easily it can be lost AND
- You see the infinite gap between your high and the true peak

This is why **the most arrogant people are usually those with the least to be arrogant about.** The truly accomplished see the ceiling above them, the gap between achievement and perfection, and the fragility of their position. The unaccomplished see only the people below them.

Conclusion

התבוננות אמיתית מחייבת שלא להתגאות בשום עניין מענייני העולם הזה

True analytical reflection requires us to take pride in nothing in this world — neither the purely physical, nor the materially-enabled, nor even the genuinely spiritual.

The Throughline of This Shiur

We've now covered Method 2b (mitzvot) and the opening of Method 3 (philosophical analysis):

- **The mitzvot** train humility through structured action: love of the stranger, Yovel, bikurim, vidui, banishment, standing for elders, the Mizbe'ach, the king's Sefer Torah
- **The philosophical analysis** dissolves each potential basis for arrogance:
- Physical things → identical to animals, fragile, self-undermining
- Material/positional things → temporal, strife-generating, lethal at their height
- Spiritual/intellectual things → dependent on physical conditions, asymptotic to true perfection, yielding paradoxically MORE humility the higher one rises

The deepest insight: Moshe was the most humble *because* he was the greatest. The closer you come to the truth, the more visible the gap becomes.

Coming Up Next

- **Continued philosophical analysis** — Rabbi Avraham continues this theme, then discusses celestial bodies and their (Rambam's view) intellectual nature
- **Religious arrogance** — the special case of pride in religious accomplishment
- **Humility vis-à-vis other humans and vis-à-vis Hakadosh Baruch Hu** — the two relationships in their fullness
- This will likely take another shiur and a half before we conclude Chapter 7

B'Ezrat Hashem

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